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57 New Marine Species Discovered in Argentina's Submarine Canyons

Ocean Census and Schmidt Ocean Institute fast-track South Atlantic species identification in Buenos Aires, as a viral deep-sea expedition leads to new species discoveries

Media Assets & Press Kit

- Scientists from Ocean Census Network identified 57 new species and 5 new genera in just two weeks.
- Specimens from the August 2025 Schmidt Ocean Institute deep-sea expedition in Argentina's Mar del Plata Canyon that live-streamed a starfish to global fame.
- New species include "Loki the Sea Cucumber" (*Peniagone* sp.), a remarkable abundance of deep-sea copepods, and 5 new scientific genera spanning corals, sea cucumbers, and crustaceans.
- Hosted by the Universidad Maimónides in collaboration with Schmidt Ocean Institute, CONICET, and the Museo Argentino de Ciencias Naturales.

BUENOS AIRES (September, 2026) – An international Species Discovery Workshop, led by the Nippon Foundation-Nekton Ocean Census in partnership with the Schmidt Ocean Institute, has resulted in the identification of **57 new marine species** and **5 genera**, shedding new light on one of the most biologically dynamic regions in the South Atlantic Ocean.

The workshop brought together 20 taxonomists and early-career researchers from across Latin America and Europe to examine deep-sea biological samples, primarily from the Schmidt Ocean Institute Underwater Oasis of the Mar del Plata Canyon expedition in August 2025 onboard Schmidt Ocean Institute's research vessel *Falkor (too)*, using the remotely operated vehicle (ROV) *SuBastian*. Hosted at the Universidad Maimónides in Buenos Aires from 13–24 July 2026, the team utilised integrated taxonomy techniques to rapidly identify specimens, logging discoveries directly onto **Ocean Census NOVA**, the world's first open-access data platform for newly discovered marine species.

> A standout discovery of the workshop, this striking deep-sea holothurian (sea cucumber) was named "Loki" for its prominent horned appendages, reminiscent of the god in Norse mythology. Captured in high-definition in-situ video and images on the seafloor of the Mar del Plata Submarine Canyon, it represents one of up to 10 new holothurian species uncovered during the Argentina workshop.ROV SuBastian / Schmidt Ocean Institute

Among the key findings was **"Loki the Sea Cucumber"** (*Peniagone* sp.), a striking deep-sea echinoderm named for its horned appendages, resembling the god of Norse legend. In total, the team identified 20 new species of copepods, 22 echinoderms (sea cucumbers and crinoids), 14 cnidarians

(octocorals, sea pens, and stony corals), and 1 scaphopod mollusc, with 5 new scientific genera spanning corals, sea cucumbers, and crustaceans.

“International cooperation in taxonomy is critical, especially in groups with few active specialists. The species discovery workshop accelerated species identification, the recognition of species new to science, and increased capacity building for local early-career taxonomists working on deep-sea fauna.” Dr. Daniel Lauretta, Principal Investigator, CONICET, and the Museo Argentino de Ciencias Naturales

Species Spotlights & Workshop Highlights

- **“Loki the Sea Cucumber” (*Peniagone sp.*)**
  Location: Mar del Plata Submarine Canyon | Depth: 2577 metres
  Taxonomist: Francisco Alonso Solís-Marín & Mariano Martinez
  This holothurian (sea cucumber) was one of the standout new species identified during the workshop. Featuring remarkable *in-situ* images and video captured on the seafloor, “Loki” represents one of up to 10 new holothurian species uncovered during the workshop.
- **The copepod collection (*Copepoda, Harpacticoida*)**
  Location: Argentina Deep Basin / Mar del Plata Canyon
  Of these tiny and vital crustaceans, taxonomists examined just 10% of the collected samples during the workshop. Yet, remarkably, **every specimen examined was a species new to science**, yielding 20 new species and 1 new genus.
- **Deep-sea corals & sea pens (*Octocorallia, Pennatuloidea, Scleractinia*)**
  Location: Mar del Plata Submarine Canyon
  The workshop identified 14 new species of corals, including two potential new genera and a potential new family (awaiting genetic analysis). Highlights include the sea pen *Pseudumbellula sp.* and the vivid orange-red octocoral *Orstomisis sp.*, providing crucial data on habitat-forming deep-sea ecosystems.

One Year On: Building on the Schmidt Ocean Institute Underwater Oases of the Mar del Plata Canyon Expedition

> Principal Investigator Dr. Daniel Lauretta examines deep-sea marine specimens during the international Species Discovery Workshop. Hosted by Universidad Maimónides in collaboration with Schmidt Ocean Institute, CONICET, and the Museo Argentino de Ciencias Naturales, the workshop brought together 20 taxonomists to process samples gathered from the Mar del Plata Canyon.The Nippon Foundation-Nekton Ocean Census / Schmidt Ocean Institute

The workshop marks the one-year anniversary of the **Schmidt Ocean Institute Underwater Oases of the Mar del Plata Canyon expedition** (July–August 2025), led by Principal Investigator Dr. Daniel Lauretta aboard Schmidt Ocean Institute’s research vessel *Falkor (too)*.

Explorations focused on the Brazil–Malvinas Confluence, where warm subtropical currents collide with cold, nutrient-rich sub-Antarctic waters to create an oceanographic crossroad of immense biological productivity. Operating in a submarine canyon nearly twice as deep as the Grand Canyon (exceeding 3,500 metres), the team used ROV *SuBastian* to broadcast live video feeds directly to the public.

Over 4 million viewers tuned in live to witness sprawling deep-sea coral reefs, fields of mushroom coral at 1,500 metres depth, including observing a bright orange seastar that captured global imagination for its resemblance to the cartoon character **“Patrick Star”.** Despite gaining global fame during and after the expedition, “Patrick Star” was not thought to be a new species, and was left undisturbed and unaware of its notoriety.

“Discovering 57 new species and five new genera in just two weeks demonstrates the speed and power of collaborative taxonomy. The deep sea holds some of the least understood ecosystems on Earth. By bringing Latin America’s scientific expertise and international experts together with, as well as connecting them to the open-access Ocean Census NOVA platform, we are drastically accelerating our understanding of marine biodiversity.” Dr Michelle Taylor, Ocean Census Head of Science.

Regional Significance for Argentina & Looking Ahead to 2027

Beyond immediate species counts, the workshop represented a major investment in Argentine scientific capacity and regional biodiversity research. Physical specimens processed during the workshop, as well as historical samples from CONICET’s *Talud Continental I–III* expeditions, a series of deep-sea scientific expeditions conducted in 2012 and 2013 to explore the marine biodiversity off the coast of Buenos Aires Province, will be permanently housed in national institutional collections, including the **Museo Argentino de Ciencias Naturales “Bernardino Rivadavia” (MACN)** in Buenos Aires.

The initiative provided hands-on training for Early Career Researchers and students, allowing knowledge exchange between local and international taxonomic experts.

> The full team of international taxonomists, regional experts, and early-career researchers assembled at Universidad Maimónides in Buenos Aires. Over two weeks, the collaborative team rapidly identified 57 new marine species and 5 new scientific genera from deep-sea samples, logging their findings directly to the open-access Ocean Census NOVA platform.The Nippon Foundation-Nekton Ocean Census / Schmidt Ocean Institute

“The Mar del Plata Canyon expedition captured the public’s imagination when we first live-streamed Argentina’s deep-sea, discovering potential new marine species,” said Dr. Jyotika Virmani, Schmidt Ocean Institute’s Executive Director. “These results show the power when world-class technology and expertise meets international scientific collaboration. By identifying new species, these scientists have advanced our understanding of South Atlantic marine life and, via Ocean Census, ensured that this data is accessible globally.”

> Schmidt Ocean Institute’s 110-metre state-of-the-art research vessel Falkor (too), which served as the operational mobile base for the August 2025 deep-sea expedition in Argentina’s Mar del Plata Canyon. The vessel enabled scientists to explore submarine canyons at depths exceeding 3,500 metres along the biological crossroad of the Brazil–Malvinas Confluence.Schmidt Ocean Institute

The discovery journey in the South Atlantic is far from over. Building on this success, Principal Investigator Dr. Daniel Lauretta and team are planning a follow-up expedition with Schmidt Ocean Institute in **February–March 2027** to a different submarine canyon with anticipated high endemism.

New samples of marine invertebrates collected during the upcoming expedition will potentially yield more new species and genera, necessitating further collaborative species discovery efforts, such as the recent Species Discovery Workshop.

About the Organisations

The Nippon Foundation-Nekton Ocean Census
The Nippon Foundation–Nekton Ocean Census is the world's largest initiative dedicated to accelerating the discovery of ocean life. Although the ocean covers over 70% of the planet, it remains one of Earth's least explored ecosystems, with only about 240,000 marine species formally documented—while millions more are thought to remain undiscovered.

Launched in April 2023 by The Nippon Foundation and Nekton, Ocean Census is a global mission designed to close this knowledge gap. Through major expeditions, advanced technologies and a worldwide scientific network, the programme is transforming how quickly we can document and understand marine life. Ocean Census is endorsed by the UN Ocean Decade and supported by partners across science, media, philanthropy, business and civil society.
www.oceancensus.org

Schmidt Ocean Institute
Schmidt Ocean Institute was established in 2009 by Eric and Wendy Schmidt to catalyse the discoveries needed to understand our ocean, sustain life, and ensure the health of our planet through the pursuit of impactful scientific research and intelligent observation, technological advancement, open sharing of information, and public engagement, all at the highest levels of international excellence.
www.schmidtocean.org

CONICET & MACN
The National Scientific and Technical Research Council (CONICET) is the primary agency promoting science and technology in Argentina. The Museo Argentino de Ciencias Naturales "Bernardino Rivadavia" (MACN) belongs to CONICET and is one of Argentina's premier natural history institutions, housing critical biological collections.
www.conicet.gov.ar
https://www.macnconicet.gob.ar/